Chapter 15 | Written solutions

Delta Rules and Hybrid Stacks

These solutions cover all ten exercises, from a hand calculation to a controlled comparison. A delta update corrects a prediction at a key; overlapping queries can feel that correction too. A hybrid keeps a separate store at every layer, and its full-attention caches still grow with the prefix. We check these ideas with small arrays before discussing what a trained-model experiment could establish.

The notebook and both PDF editions follow the chapter's exercise order. The written edition contains every derivation and interpretation, while the notebook edition also includes the code and saved outputs. The fixed teaching models are not trained language models and their traces do not measure task accuracy.

1. Read the Jamba schedule

Use one-based layer numbers. Each eight-layer block has attention at position five and Mamba at its other positions. Its MoE sublayers occupy positions two, four, six, and eight; all four therefore follow recurrent mixers. Adding offsets $0, 8, 16, 24$ gives

Block	Full-stack layers	Growing KV cache	Recurrent mixer followed by MoE
1	1–8	5	2, 4, 6, 8
2	9–16	13	10, 12, 14, 16
3	17–24	21	18, 20, 22, 24
4	25–32	29	26, 28, 30, 32

There are four growing caches and 16 recurrent-plus-MoE layers. Layer 14 is position six of the second block. It uses Mamba followed by MoE, whose router selects two of its 16 experts for the token. The token still visits the same mixer type as every other token at layer 14.

The fraction $2/16$ describes expert selection inside one MoE sublayer. Attention or Mamba projections, normalization, dense sublayers, routers, embeddings and other shared components also participate in the model. Consequently, the active fraction of all model parameters is not obtained by multiplying the total parameter count by $2/16$. These schedules refer to the original Jamba-v0.1 checkpoint.

2. Count bytes across different stores

At each token the cache adds three key coordinates and two value coordinates. Each uses two bytes, so the cache grows by $(3 + 2) \cdot 2 = 10$ bytes per token. The two recurrent states contain $12 + 8 = 20$ scalars at four bytes each, giving 80 bytes independent of prefix length. Thus the per-sequence payload is

$$B(n) = n(3 + 2) \cdot 2 + (12 + 8) \cdot 4 = 10n + 80 \quad \text{bytes.}$$

Prefix n	Attention cache	First recurrent state	Second recurrent state	Total
7	70 B	48 B	32 B	150 B
14	140 B	48 B	32 B	220 B

Doubling the prefix doubles the cache contribution but leaves the recurrent contribution at 80 bytes. The total therefore grows from 150 to 220 bytes. Count each live store once; these are numeric payload bytes, excluding parameters, temporary arrays and allocator overhead.

3. Correct one column

The key and query $(0,1)^\top$ select the second column. First multiply every entry of the original state by $1/2$, then read the prediction at that key:

$$\widetilde{S} = \frac{1}{2}\begin{bmatrix}1 & 2\\ 0 & 3\end{bmatrix} = \begin{bmatrix}1/2 & 1\\ 0 & 3/2\end{bmatrix}, \qquad \widehat{v} = \widetilde{S}k = \begin{bmatrix}1\\ 3/2\end{bmatrix}.$$

The new value is $(4,-1)^\top$, so the error is $(3,-5/2)^\top$. The outer product puts that error in column two and zeros in column one. Scaling it by $\beta = 1/4$ gives

$$\beta e k^\top = \begin{bmatrix}0 & 3/4\\ 0 & -5/8\end{bmatrix}, \qquad S_{\text{new}} = \begin{bmatrix}1/2 & 7/4\\ 0 & 7/8\end{bmatrix}.$$

The output is the updated second column, $(7/4, 7/8)^\top = (1.75, 0.875)^\top$. It has moved one quarter of the way from the decayed prediction toward the new value. Column one changes from $(1,0)^\top$ to $(1/2,0)^\top$ through decay alone; its write contribution is zero.

4. Trace a sign change

Restart from $S = I$ each time. The zero value contributes no new write, and $k = (1,0)^\top$ selects the first direction. Thus

$$S_{\text{new}} = 0.6I(I - \beta k k^\top) = \begin{bmatrix}0.6(1-\beta) & 0\\ 0 & 0.6\end{bmatrix}.$$

The first coordinate query selects the first column; the second selects the second column.

β	**Read at** $(1,0)^\top$	**Read at** $(0,1)^\top$
0.5	$(0.3,0)^\top$	$(0,0.6)^\top$
1	$(0,0)^\top$	$(0,0.6)^\top$
1.5	$(-0.3,0)^\top$	$(0,0.6)^\top$

The correction moves the decayed prediction $(0.6,0)^\top$ toward the zero target: halfway, exactly to zero, or past zero. Only the addressed direction changes sign. The decay coefficient itself remains positive.

For the separate scalar example, prediction 2 and target 5 give $2 + 1.5(5-2) = 6.5$. Equivalently, $(1-1.5)2 + 1.5\cdot 5 = -1 + 7.5 = 6.5$. The negative coefficient multiplies the old prediction; the new write can make the final answer positive. A negative carry coefficient is not a claim that every output will be negative.

5. Check a read with Python

Exercise 3 gave the updated state $\left(\begin{smallmatrix}1/2 & 7/4\\ 0 & 7/8\end{smallmatrix}\right)$. The key determines the correction, while the query chooses a read afterward. We now hold the original state, key, value and gates fixed, and change only the query. Each call starts from the same original state; feeding the first result into the second call would apply a second write.

For this particular state, the first basis query reads $(1/2,0)^\top$ and the second reads $(7/4,7/8)^\top$. The terms in the update use the key and value, with no query term. The final multiplication uses the query. Check the shared matrix and the individual readouts in float64 with absolute tolerance 10^{-12} and zero relative tolerance. Both results here use fractions whose denominators are powers of two, which float64 can represent exactly at these magnitudes.

Now turn decay off and make a complete correction with $\alpha = \beta = 1$. For the unit key $(0, 1)^\top$, one write gives $S' = \left(\begin{smallmatrix} 1 & 4 \\ 0 & -1 \end{smallmatrix}\right)$. Its read already equals v, so the next identical write has zero error and leaves S' unchanged. This is idempotence of this particular write, with no intervening decay or other update.

With the nonunit key $(0, 2)^\top$, the original prediction is $(4, 6)^\top$ and the error is $(0, -7)^\top$. The first state becomes $\left(\begin{smallmatrix} 1 & 2 \\ 0 & -11 \end{smallmatrix}\right)$ and reads $(4, -22)^\top$ at that key. A second write gives $\left(\begin{smallmatrix} 1 & 2 \\ 0 & 31 \end{smallmatrix}\right)$ and read $(4, 62)^\top$. The squared key length is four, so $\beta = 1$ multiplies the error in its own read by four. The low-level function uses supplied vectors directly; the stack helper normalizes its recurrent keys.

6. Watch three stores grow

Follow one token at a time through three layers. Layers 1 and 3 use delta updates and each carries its own 2×2 matrix state. Layer 2 uses full attention and carries two arrays, one for keys and one for values. Both arrays start with zero rows and have feature width two. Each token adds one row to each array. After t tokens, the shapes are $(t, 2)$ and $(t, 2)$, with $2t$ key scalars and $2t$ value scalars.

Each delta state represents the accumulated effects of its layer's writes in the same four entries. Its entries can change at every step. Its shape stays fixed. The attention layer keeps one key and one value vector per token, so its history grows by four scalars per step. The expected layer counts are therefore $(4, 4t, 4)$. The total includes both separate delta matrices and both parts of the attention cache, giving $8 + 4t$ scalars.

After reading	Layer 1 delta	Layer 2 keys	Layer 2 values	Layer 3 delta	Total scalars
No tokens	4	0	0	4	8
$(1, 2)$	4	2	2	4	12
$(0, 1)$	4	4	4	4	16
$(-1, 2)$	4	6	6	4	20

The second layer receives the representation produced by layer 1 at this step. The projection rule makes this incoming representation the new key and swaps its two coordinates to form the new value. The attention cache therefore stores the first layer's transformed features. Check the newest row in each array against that rule.

Each iteration passes forward the **returned** stores. The input and intermediate representations in `trace` let us inspect this step. They are not additional persistent history. The old state and old cache objects are replaced by their new versions, so adding the counts from successive steps would double-count retained history. With eight bytes per float64 scalar, the three measured totals after inputs 1, 2, and 3 are 96, 128, and 160 bytes. Those numbers count the array payload only and exclude parameters, temporary attention work, and Python object overhead.



7. Change the middle mixer

Feed the same sequence $(1, 2)$, $(0, 1)$, $(-1, 2)$ through two three-layer stacks. The hybrid has delta, attention, and delta mixers. The other has three delta mixers. Each run starts with its own fresh stores and passes the returned stores to the next token. Each mixer's output becomes the next mixer's input for the same token.

For every token, `trace[0]` is the original representation. Entries `trace[1]`, `trace[2]`, and `trace[3]` are the outputs of the three successive mixers. Compare the first- and third-layer outputs for the final token. Also inspect the middle output and the last layer's state just before that token to see where the difference comes from.

The first mixer has the same update rule, initial state, and input history in both runs. In each case the query and key are the incoming vector normalized to unit length. The value swaps its two coordinates. The gates are $\alpha = 3/4$ and $\beta = 1/2$. The first layer therefore follows the same sequence of states and gives the same representation for every token.

We can compute entry 1 of the final trace by hand. Let $a = 1/\sqrt{5}$ and write S_1 and S_2 for the first layer's states after the first and second tokens. The first key is $(a, 2a)^\top$ and the value is $(2, 1)^\top$. From zero, the update is half their outer product. The second token uses key $(0, 1)^\top$, so after decay only column 2 receives a correction.

$$S_1 = a \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 2 \\ 1/2 & 1 \end{bmatrix}, \qquad S_2 = \begin{bmatrix} 3a/4 & 1/2 + 3a/4 \\ 3a/8 & 3a/8 \end{bmatrix}.$$

For the third token, the query and key are both $k = (-a, 2a)^\top$, and the value is $v = (2, -1)^\top$. The decayed prediction $p = (3/4)S_2 k$ is $(3a/4 + 9/80,\ 9/160)^\top$. Reading along the same unit key after the update gives $p + \frac{1}{2}(v - p) = \frac{1}{2}(p + v)$. The first layer's final output is therefore $(169/160 + 3a/8,\ -151/320)^\top$, approximately $(1.223955098,\ -0.471875)$.

At entry 2, the hybrid's attention mixer reads from the three stored keys and values. The all-delta middle mixer instead reads its updated matrix state. The final token reaches layer 3 as about $(-0.03556, 1.05935)$ in the hybrid and $(-0.19066, 0.78165)$ in the all-delta stack. Their preceding tokens also produced different middle outputs, so layer 3 enters the final step with a different matrix in each run.

The two last mixers follow the same rule. Each decays its own preceding state, forms a new prediction along the normalized incoming direction, and corrects toward the swapped incoming value. This calculation reconstructs that read from the saved preceding state and the current middle output. The final outputs are about $(0.74868, 0.07153)$ and $(0.51177, -0.05517)$, respectively. The last mixer type is the same, but both the information entering it now and the information it carried from earlier tokens have changed. The NumPy comparisons use float64 with absolute tolerance 10^{-12} and zero relative tolerance, except for the exact check between the identical first-layer traces.

8. Check the cache against a full pass (optional)

Use the one-layer schedule `("attention",)` and the three input rows $(1, 0)$, $(0, 1)$, and $(1, 1)$. In the teaching attention layer, the query and key are the input itself and the value swaps its two features. This gives $Q = K$ equal to the input matrix and value rows $(0, 1)$, $(1, 0)$, and $(1, 1)$. In a full pass we compute all the queries together. A Boolean lower-triangular mask permits key j for query i exactly when $j \le i$. The diagonal keeps each token's own key available.

The two-feature dot product is divided by $\sqrt{2}$. For a hand check, put $s = 1/\sqrt{2}$ and $r = e^{-s}$. Subtracting the largest allowed score from each row before exponentiating gives the following mixtures.

Query	Allowed key positions	Allowed scores	Output
1	1	(s)	$(0, 1)$
2	1, 2	$(0, s)$	$(1, r)/(1 + r)$
3	1, 2, 3	$(s, s, 2s)$	$(1 + r, 1 + r)/(1 + 2r)$

For example, query 3 has normalized weights $(r, r, 1)/(1 + 2r)$. Both output coordinates receive a contribution 1 from the last value and a contribution r from one of the other values before division.

Now feed the tokens one at a time. The cache starts empty, and each call appends the incoming key and value before computing attention. The first call sees only position 1. The second sees positions 1 and 2, and the third sees all three. Thus each streaming query sees exactly the entries its row of the full mask allows. Check the contents of both cached arrays after every call, and compare the last entry of each trace with the corresponding full-pass output.

The two methods give the same three output rows within the float64 absolute tolerance 10^{-12} with zero relative tolerance. The stored keys and values match the full-pass projections exactly at every prefix. Equality follows because each query uses the same projection, scaling, and ordered set of visible keys and values. In the streaming pass that set is defined by the prefix already in the cache. In the full pass it is defined by the Boolean mask.

For the causality check, replace only input three by $(3, -2)$. The first two rows of queries, keys and values are unchanged. Their masks exclude position three, so their outputs must remain unchanged. In the streaming calculation the third input has not even arrived when those outputs are formed. The third output can change because it reads its own new key and value as well as the preceding entries.

9. Write to overlapping directions (optional)

There is one value coordinate, so S is a row of length two. With no decay and a complete correction, $S_{\text{new}} = S + (v - Sk)k^\top$. The first unit key $k_1 = (1, 0)^\top$ and value 2 give $S_1 = (2, 0)$ from a zero state.

For the overlapping key $k_2 = (1/\sqrt{2}, 1/\sqrt{2})^\top$, the prediction is $\sqrt{2}$ and the error is $5 - \sqrt{2}$. Hence

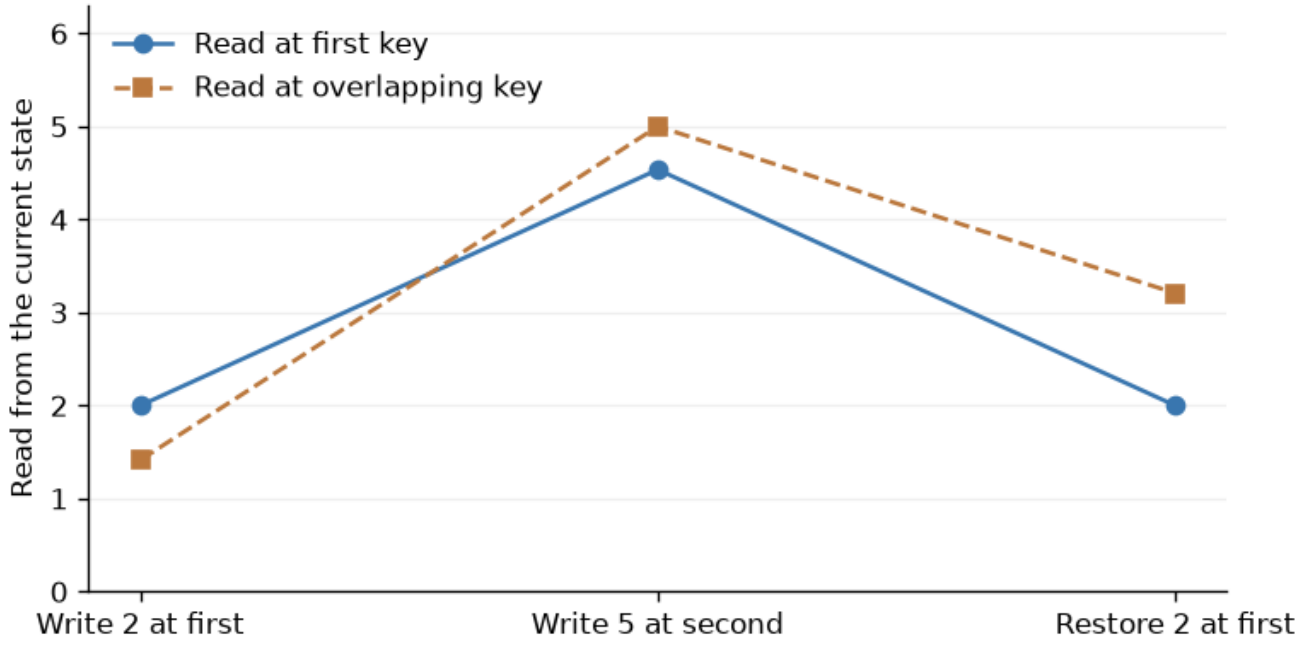
$$S_2 = (2, 0) + (5 - \sqrt{2})(1/\sqrt{2}, 1/\sqrt{2}) = \left(1 + \frac{5}{\sqrt{2}}, \frac{5}{\sqrt{2}} - 1\right).$$

The second key reads exactly 5. The first key now reads $1 + 5/\sqrt{2} \approx 4.535534$, rather than 2. The read-change formula predicts this: the second write changes the first read by $(5 - \sqrt{2})(k_2^\top k_1) = (5 - \sqrt{2})/\sqrt{2}$.

For the orthogonal second key $(0, 1)^\top$, restart from zero and make the same first write. The second prediction is zero; the second write adds $(0, 5)$ and gives $S_2 = (2, 5)$. Its two reads are 2 and 5. The inner product with the old key is zero, so that old read receives no correction.

Second key	First read before	First read after	Second read after
Overlapping	2	$1 + 5/\sqrt{2} \approx 4.535534$	5
Orthogonal	2	2	5

Finally restore value 2 at k_1 in the overlapping run. This resets only the first coordinate, giving $S_3 = (2, 5/\sqrt{2}-1)$. The second key now reads $(2+5/\sqrt{2}-1)/\sqrt{2} = 5/2+1/\sqrt{2} \approx 3.207107$. Correcting the old association disturbed the newer one. Each individual unit-key write is exact at its own key; that does not make several overlapping associations independently editable.



10. Plan a controlled comparison (optional)

Begin with a table mapping indices 0–3 to Ash, Birch, Cedar and Elm. Let the initial active index be 2. The moves advance, advance and retreat produce indices $3, 0, 3$. The same history supports three different questions:

Question	Answer	Information needed
Address at index 1?	Birch	A specified entry of the early table
Current active index?	3	Initial index and subsequent moves
Address at current index?	Elm	Updated index, then the corresponding entry

The first is recall, the second is tracking, and the third composes them. A reference generator should calculate the answers exactly before any model is evaluated.

For a reproducible protocol, draw distinct address labels of equal token length and randomly assign them to indices on each sequence. Sample the initial index uniformly, state it explicitly, and draw moves independently of the table. Choose the specified-index query independently of the final index. Changing the mapping prevents a model from answering through a fixed learned index-to-address rule. Include paired histories with identical last messages but different earlier moves or initial indices, and others with identical trajectories but different table entries.

Train on tables with 4–8 entries and 8–32 moves. Test both within that range and beyond it, for example with 16 or 32 entries and 64 or 128 moves. Vary table size and move count separately before combining them, and record total token length as well. Increasing only the number of moves over a fixed eight-entry table does not increase the amount of arbitrary address information that must be retained. A sufficiently large fixed state could store that whole table.

Split complete table mappings and trajectory families into training, validation and test sets before combining them into questions. Reject a held-out mapping or an initial-index-plus-move sequence if it occurs in training; keep all three questions and any paired variants of one history in the same split. Use validation data for configuration and checkpoint selection. The candidate generator needs these split checks before use in a training experiment.

Match causal depth, residual width, feed-forward sublayers, embeddings and output head across the three model families. Choose and report a fixed mixer schedule for the hybrid. Match tokenizer, training examples, training-token exposure, optimizer, learning-rate schedule and checkpoint selection rule; use several paired seeds. Mixer parameters and compute may still differ, so report them rather than claiming that equal width also equalizes total parameters or FLOPs. A second study can match a compute budget if that is the question of interest.

Measure exact match separately for recall, tracking and the combined question at every table size and move count. Use the same answer format and decoding rule for every model. Also report the fraction of histories on which all three answers are correct, and a diagnostic combined question that supplies the true final index. Correct tracking with an incorrect current address points toward trouble retrieving or using the indexed entry. Do not infer an architectural limitation from one failed training run.

Measure persistent history bytes per sequence just after the reports and before the question, using a common storage precision where feasible. Sum live K/V payloads and recurrent state plus convolution buffers across layers. Report reserved cache capacity separately. Parameters, saved output traces, temporary workspaces and allocator overhead are different quantities. At batch size one, a recurrent head with shape $[d_v, d_k]$ holds sd_vd_k bytes, and a full-attention layer holds $snH_{\mathrm{KV}}(d_k + d_v)$ bytes when all components use s bytes per scalar. The teaching stacks below use float64 and no auxiliary buffers, so their bytes are eight times their scalar counts.

The circular task has a shortcut: the final index is the initial index plus the sum of the moves, modulo table size. The moves commute, so their order is irrelevant. It is a useful first pipeline check, but it does not reproduce the harder state-tracking problems used to study expressivity.

For an order-sensitive extension, let each update swap two index labels. A pointer at either label moves to the other; a pointer elsewhere stays put. Starting at index 1, swaps $(1, 2)$ then $(2, 3)$ produce $1 \to 2 \to 3$. Reversing those swaps gives $1 \to 1 \to 2$. The tables can stay fixed while the pointer changes. These updates remove the simple sum-of-moves shortcut, but performance still has to be measured in trained models; this generator and its oracle are not an empirical advantage for any architecture.